hands, the CDU, on the other hand, received the less important culture department).

Throughout this period, Honecker cast his net far and wide to enlist recruits to the FDJ by adopting the posture of a young go-getter, full of gung-ho spirit and vitality. SED photo archives show him dribbling a football during a sporting afternoon, whistling up a group of teenagers for a cycle ride and helping clear rubble in Prenzlauer Berg. Using the four-point slogan ‘unity, work, construction and peace,’ he found male teenagers generally enthusiastic, but recruiting girls, he complained, became a reoccurring headache as they were mostly interested in dancing, chocolate, cosmetics and cigarettes, like young women in the West. ‘We have to meet their desire for a happy life,’ he grumped. His talent stretched to designing a colourful uniform stitched from mustard yellow and sea blue fabrics with the FDJ logo of the rising sun sewn on the left shirt sleeve. The ceremonial parade uniform, which included a bright red neckerchief and side-cap, was, according to Honecker, intended to ‘develop young people’s sense of togetherness and promote their fighting spirit’.9 The logo represented that ‘after the pitch-dark night of fascism, a new day was dawning for the German youth’.10 All youngsters between the ages of 14 and 25, apart from former full-time Hitler Youth members, were eligible to join the FDJ at the counters of local offices springing up across the Soviet zone. But unlike the Hitler Youth, the FDJ avoided torch-lit parades and semi-military training, instead emphasising character building, indoctrination and physical training. It was mixed-sex and provided educational activities for those from disadvantaged backgrounds.

In later years, when SED ‘court historians’ wrote Honecker’s biography, a chapter devoted to 1945–46, painted a portrait of a heroic man inspired by the ‘indomitable will to do everything possible to seize the opportunity offered to the German people by liberation from fascism’.11

As an activist from the very beginning, he used all his strength to eradicate fascism and militarism, to establish a new anti-fascist democratic state and to steer social development along the path of socialism.12 ‘Honecker’s tremendous effort,’ the biography explained, was focused not just on gathering working-class youth, but ripping an ‘entire generation misled and